

DECODED EXPLAINED

21st July, 2026

4 Indian Seafarers Killed Near Odessa

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NEW DELHI

Four Indian citizens were killed and one was critically injured in an attack on a merchant vessel near the Ukrainian port of Odessa on Sunday. India condemned the incident and called such attacks impeding freedom of navigation “deplorable”.

The Ministry of External Affairs on Monday reiterated India’s opposition to attacks on merchant vessels as such incidents violate the freedom of navigation.

First instance

The incident near Ukraine’s largest sea port in the Black Sea is the first instance of Indian seafarers being killed in the Russia-Ukraine war that started in February 2022.

Ukraine’s Acting Foreign Minister, Andrii Sybaha, has blamed Russia for the attack and said five crew members of the ship remain missing.



Smoke rises from the vessel *MV Golden Leo* after an alleged Russian attack on Sunday. AFP

“On the evening of 19 July 2022, the vessel *MV Golden Leo* was attacked while departing the port of Odessa. At the time of the incident, there were 17 crew members on board, including five Indian nationals. As per information available, four Indian nationals have tragically lost their lives, while one is hospitalised in a critical condition,” read a statement from the Ministry of External Affairs.

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● The Incident

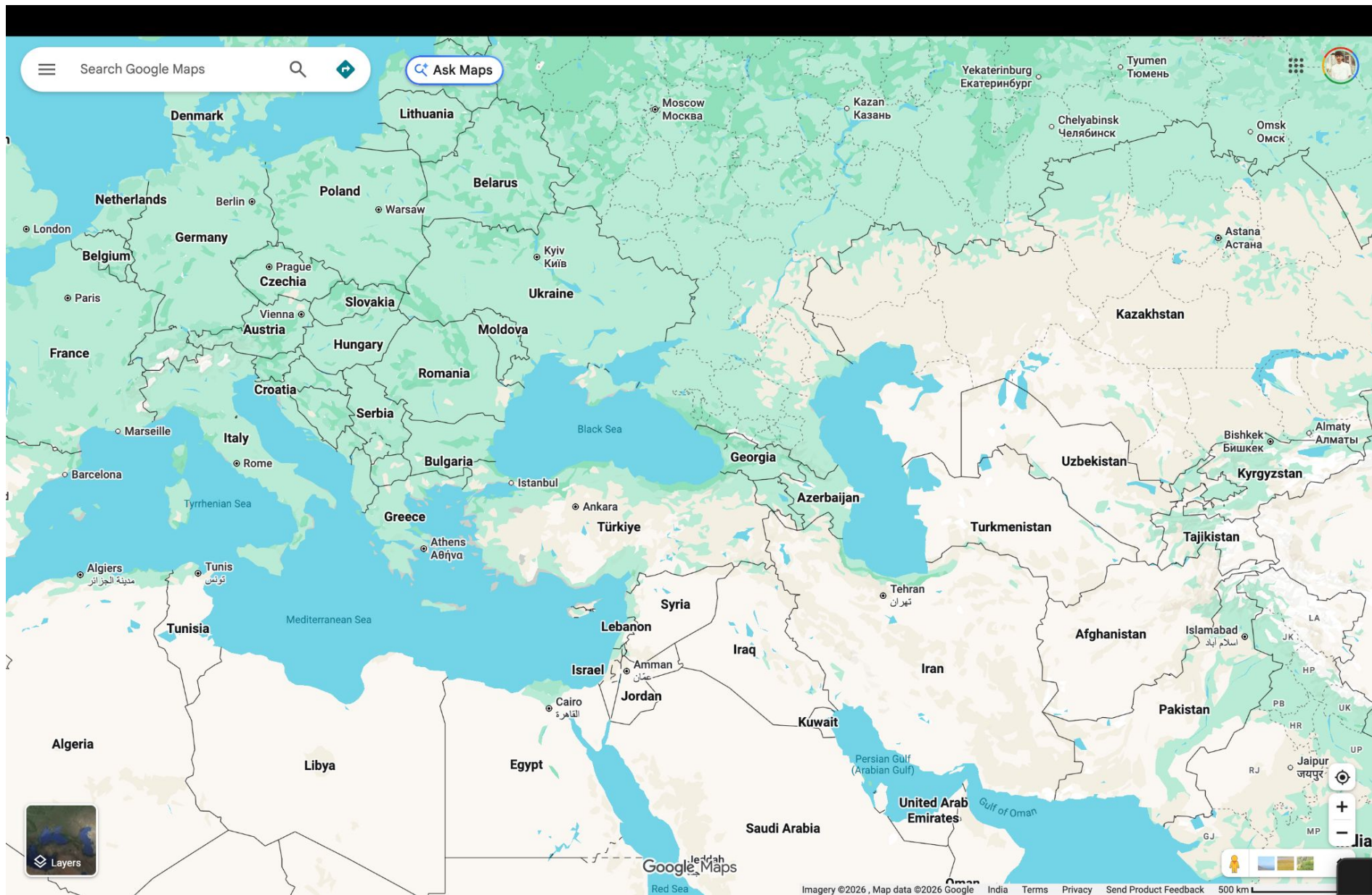
- Four Indian citizens were killed and one was critically injured in an attack on the merchant vessel MV Golden Leo near Ukraine's port of Odessa on Sunday, July 19, 2026
- The vessel was attacked while departing the port of Odessa; 17 crew members were on board, including five Indian nationals
- India's Ministry of External Affairs confirmed four Indian nationals had died while one was hospitalised in critical condition

● India's Response

- India condemned the incident and called such attacks impeding freedom of navigation “deplorable”
- The Ministry of External Affairs reiterated India's opposition to attacks on merchant vessels as violations of the freedom of navigation

● Attribution & Context

- Ukraine's Acting Foreign Minister, Andrii Sybiha, blamed Russia for the attack and said five crew members remain missing
- This is the first instance of Indian seafarers being killed in the Russia-Ukraine war, which began in February 2022
- The incident occurred near Ukraine's largest sea port on the Black Sea



4 Indian Seafarers Killed Near Odessa



Mediterranean Sea

Bordering Countries (21 countries): Morocco, Algeria, Tunisia, Libya, Egypt, Israel, Lebanon, Syria, Turkey, Greece, Albania, Montenegro, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Croatia, Slovenia, Italy, France and Spain
Islands : Cyprus and Malta

To the west it is connected to the Atlantic Ocean through the Strait of Gibraltar, to the east with the Black Sea through the Dardanelles Straits, and to the south with the Red Sea through Suez Canal.
Nile river (Africa) drains into the Mediterranean Sea.

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Adriatic Sea

Physical Geography:

Arm of the Mediterranean Sea, lying between Italy and the Balkan Peninsula.

It extends from the Gulf of Venice south to the Strait of Otranto, linking it to the Ionian Sea.

Bordering Countries: Italy, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro, Albania and Slovenia.

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Black sea

- The **Black Sea**, also known as the **Euxine Sea**, is one of the **major water bodies** and a famous inland sea of the world.
- The bordering countries of the Black Sea can be remembered as **BURGeR-T: Bulgaria, Ukraine, Russia, Georgia, Romania and Türkiye**
- **Maritime Boundary**: It is linked to the Sea of Marmara through the Bosphorus Strait and then to the Aegean Sea (an elongated embayment of the Mediterranean Sea) through the Dardanelles Strait.
- The **Turkish straits system** (the Dardanelles, Bosphorus and the Marmara Sea) forms a transitional zone between the Mediterranean and the Black Sea.
- The **Black Sea** is also connected to the **Sea of Azov by the Strait of Kerch**.
- **Surrounding Mountains**: The Black Sea is surrounded by the Pontic in the South, the Caucasus in the East, and the Crimean Mountains in the North.

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Caspian Sea

Physical Geography:

Earth's largest inland body of water, when measured by surface area.

Bordered by Russia (northwest), Azerbaijan (west), Iran (south), Turkmenistan (southeast) and Kazakhstan (northeast).

In 2003, the Caspian littoral states signed the **(Tehran) Framework Convention** for the Protection of the Marine Environment of the Caspian Sea.

It is an **endorheic basin** (drainage basin without an outflow).

Cities on Caspian Sea: Baku, the capital of Azerbaijan, is the largest city on the Caspian

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Q. Turkey is located between (2014)

- (a)** Black Sea and Caspian Sea
- (b)** Black Sea and Mediterranean Sea
- (c)** Gulf of Suez and Mediterranean Sea
- (d)** Gulf of Aqaba and Dead Sea

Q. Consider the following pairs: (2019)

Sea Bordering Country

- 1. Adriatic Sea : Albania
- 2. Black Sea : Croatia
- 3. Caspian Sea : Kazakhstan
- 4. Mediterranean Sea : Morocco
- 5. Red Sea : Syria

Which of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a)** 1, 2 and 4 only
- (b)** 1, 3 and 4 only
- (c)** 2 and 5 only
- (d)** 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Reclaiming Footpaths, Taking Cities Back From Cars

Reclaiming footpaths, taking cities back from cars

Few sights are more ordinary in an Indian city than a pedestrian being pushed off a footpath and onto the road. A mother, holding a school bag in one hand and a child in the other, walks around a parked car. An elderly man tests a broken footpath before stepping down onto the road. A wheelchair user gives up before the journey has even begun. A vendor, debris, an open drain, a two-wheeler, and a signboard together form what is still, with bureaucratic optimism, called a pavement. The citizen is then forced to walk on a road designed as though only vehicles possess rights.

Upholding walkability

In June 2026, the Supreme Court of India gave constitutional language to this daily indignity, in *Maniyar Ilyaz @ Shaik Riyaz vs P. Ayyappan (2026)*. It held that walking on demarcated footpaths is a fundamental constitutional right, protected under Article 19(1)(d) and Article 21 of the Constitution. It observed that pedestrians have a right to safe footpaths and footways, and directed States and Union Territories to frame policies and guidelines for their provision and maintenance. This is not a minor municipal instruction. It is a public health intervention, a road safety measure, and a democratic test of whether Indian cities are built for people or merely for machines.

The timing could not be more urgent. India is becoming less active precisely when it needs movement the most. Health risk factors and diseases such as diabetes, hypertension, fatty liver disease, and obesity are rising rapidly, as reported by every newly available population health dataset.

Walking and increased physical activity are among the low- and no-cost interventions that can halt and reverse this rise in metabolic diseases. Yet, the World Health Organization (WHO)'s India Physical Activity Profile 2024 estimates that 49.4% of Indian adults do not meet the recommended levels of physical activity; among women, the figure is 57.2%. Among children and adolescents aged 11 to 17 years, it is 74%. WHO recommends at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity physical activity each week for adults. For most citizens, this does not mean gym memberships or elite fitness routines. It means having the ability to walk safely to a bus stop, school, market, clinic, metro station, or park.

These are not failures of willpower alone; rather, they are exacerbated by the built environment. A city that makes walking difficult quietly prescribes sedentary living. Footpaths, therefore, are not decorative strips of cement



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Safe, accessible footpaths are a test of governance, revealing whether India's cities truly serve their people

added after roads have been designed. They are preventive medicine laid in stone. A usable pavement allows children to walk to school, office-goers to use public transport, older adults to remain mobile, and women to move safely. Walking improves blood pressure, insulin sensitivity, weight control, mood, sleep, and joint function. It is the simplest health habit available to the largest number of citizens. Yet, we in India have made it difficult and dangerous. Many Indians would prefer to use cars and scooters less if cities offered safe, continuous, shaded footpaths.

The road safety argument is equally compelling. The Union Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (Transport Research Wing) 'Road Accidents in India 2024' report found that two-wheeler riders and pedestrians together accounted for nearly 67% of road fatalities, with 1.28 lakh deaths among these vulnerable groups. The National Crime Records Bureau's 2024 data place the number at more than 1.1 lakh and the share at at least 60%. The exact totals differ across official sources, but the message is unambiguous: pedestrians and two-wheeler riders remain India's most vulnerable road users. Every time a footpath disappears, the road becomes a contest between flesh and metal.

Orderly shared streets

The solution cannot be episodic anti-encroachment drives, in which a few carts and cars are removed before the same disorder returns the following week. Nor can it be a punitive war on street vendors, who are workers with legal protections and legitimate economic claims. The answer lies in planned allocation: footpaths for walking, vending zones for vendors, parking spaces for vehicles, utility corridors for public infrastructure, and meaningful penalties for violations. A humane city organises the street so that livelihoods and mobility can coexist without endangering lives.

Citizens, too, have a role, though not the only one. First, walk deliberately: begin with 10 to 15 minutes after two major meals, or build towards 30 minutes at a fixed time each day. Second, convert short errands into walking errands; distances under one kilometre should not automatically require a scooter or car. Third, combine walking with public transport by using the metro, bus, or shared mobility for part of the commute. Fourth, make walking social: families, resident welfare associations, and workplaces can create walking groups and car-free morning routines. Fifth, reclaim walking as a health check. If breathlessness, knee pain, fear of falling, or

unsafe streets prevent walking, treat that as a signal to seek medical advice, improve strength, or demand civic correction. Most importantly, the recent Supreme Court decision has given citizens and resident welfare associations an opportunity to demand their right to walk on encroachment-free footpaths.

Yet, citizens cannot easily walk their way out of poor urban planning. Civic bodies and governments must act with seriousness. Every road project should include continuous, shaded, well-lit, and barrier-free footpaths, along with safe crossings. Footpaths must be wide enough for two people or a wheelchair, with ramps and clear passageways near bus stops. Encroachment control should be continuous, transparent, and fair. Parking on footpaths must invite stringent action, with penalties that change behaviour. Street design should prioritise schools, hospitals, bus stops, markets, and metro stations, where pedestrian volumes are high. Tree cover, benches, public toilets, and lighting are not embellishments; they determine whether women, children, persons with disabilities, and older people can walk.

Policy action

India also needs a national active-mobility mission linking urban development, transport, health, and education. Cities and urban planning should be assessed not by the length of flyovers built, but by the number of safe walking kilometres created. Municipal commissioners should publish ward-level footpath maps and annual audits of encroachment-free footpaths. School zones should have traffic calming measures and protected crossings. Employers should encourage active commuting. Doctors should prescribe walking advice to nudge behaviour, but governments must provide the pavements on which those prescriptions can be followed.

The Supreme Court has moved the footpath from the margins of municipal housekeeping to the centre of constitutional rights. The next task is to move it from judgment to habit, budget, design, and enforcement. A country battling diabetes, hypertension, obesity, stress, and road deaths cannot treat walking as an afterthought. India does not merely need more roads; it needs more rights of way for ordinary citizens. The footpath is where public health, dignity, and democracy meet. We need to take our cities back from cars. We need to rebuild our cities for people. The proportion of encroachment-free footpaths should become a barometer of whether elected governments value citizens' fundamental rights in every ward and on every major road.

Reclaiming Footpaths, Taking Cities Back From Cars

● The Supreme Court Ruling

- In June 2026, in Maniyar Iliyaz @ Shaik Riyaz vs P. Ayyappan (2026), the Supreme Court held that walking on demarcated footpaths is a fundamental constitutional right, protected under Article 19(1)(d) and Article 21
- The Court directed States and Union Territories to frame policies and guidelines for the provision and maintenance of footpaths, calling it a public health intervention, a road safety measure, and a democratic test of whether cities are built for people or machines

● The Public Health Case

- India's health risk factors : diabetes, hypertension, fatty liver disease, obesity are rising rapidly even as physical activity is falling
- The WHO's India Physical Activity Profile 2024 found 49.4% of Indian adults do not meet recommended activity levels (57.2% among women; 74% among children and adolescents aged 11 to 17)

● The Road Safety Case

- The Union Ministry of Road Transport and Highways' 'Road Accidents in India 2024' report found two-wheeler riders and pedestrians together account for nearly 67% of road fatalities, about 1.28 lakh deaths
- NCRB 2024 data place the number above 1.1 lakh, with a share of at least 60%

● Policy Prescriptions

- Calls for planned street allocation : footpaths for walking, vending zones for vendors, parking for vehicles, utility corridors rather than episodic anti-encroachment drives
- Recommends a national active-mobility mission, ward-level footpath maps, annual encroachment-free audits, and judging municipal performance by safe walking kilometres created rather than flyovers built

Reclaiming Footpaths, Taking Cities Back From Cars

● Urban Transport Planning Principles

- The 'Complete Streets' approach designs streets to safely accommodate all users : pedestrians, cyclists, public transport, and vehicles AND not just motor vehicles
- Encroachment on footpaths by vendors, parked vehicles, and construction remains a widespread governance failure in Indian cities

Thank You